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A Dual Time-Scale Artificial Hormone Mechanism for Fault-Tolerant CPG-Based Snake Robot Locomotion: Neuro-Endocrine Diffusion, Hill Receptor Gating, and Dynamic Spinal Bypass

Potiwat Ngamkajornwiwat[1,*]

[1]Department of Robotics and Automation Engineering, Faculty of Engineering and Technology, Panyapiwat Institute of Management, Nonthaburi 11120, Thailand
*Author to whom any correspondence should be addressed.

E-mail: potiwatnga@pim.ac.th

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Abstract

When a modular snake robot sustains an in-field actuator failure in extreme environments, its continuous traveling wave fractures, triggering uncoordinated lateral slipping, severe rotational drift, or complete locomotor paralysis. Conventional fault-tolerant strategies rely on centralized diagnostic observers that suffer from latency bottlenecks, or rigid heuristic reflexes that lack multi-segment spatial coordination. In contrast, biological vertebrates endure severe spinal cord lesions by exploiting neuro-endocrine volume transmission—slow paracrine hormone diffusion through spinal tissue that dynamically reorganizes downstream neural circuits. Inspired by this biological mechanism, we propose a local-global artificial hormone-gated central pattern generator (AHM-CPG) framework for autonomous, model-free lesion recovery without explicit fault identification. Local movement coherence deficits autonomously trigger decentralized hormone secretion along the spine via a 1D reaction-diffusion continuum. Cooperatively gated by allosteric receptor kinetics, this endocrine signal smoothly orchestrates compensatory amplitude redistribution across intact joints, constructs dynamic multi-hop phase bypass bridges across disabled segments, and actively neutralizes asymmetric curvature bias. Extensive multi-body physics simulations across diverse failure modes and environmental stress regimes demonstrate that AHM-CPG rapidly restores propulsive traveling wave continuity, stabilizes directional heading, and significantly mitigates actuator thermal dissipation stress to prevent hardware burnout. This work establishes a dual time-scale neuro-endocrine paradigm for emergent physical resilience in autonomous biorobotics.

1 Introduction

Limbless biological organisms, including snakes, eels, and caecilians, exhibit extraordinary locomotor adaptability across diverse, unstructured substrates by propagating continuous traveling curvature waves along their elongated bodies [1, 2]. In biological vertebrates, rhythmic undulatory locomotion is generated and sustained by decentralized spinal neural circuits known as Central Pattern Generators (CPGs) [3, 4, 5]. When biological networks sustain neuromuscular fatigue, trauma, or partial spinal cord transection, systemic neuro-endocrine modulators (such as serotonin, dopamine, and octopamine) diffuse through the interstitial extracellular fluid and hemolymph to alter synaptic excitability, recruit latent propriospinal pathways, and restore functional stepping [6, 7, 8, 9, 10]. This volume transmission mechanism operates concurrently across two distinct temporal scales: rapid synaptic transmission (< 100 ms) and slow hormonal diffusion and enzymatic clearance (seconds to minutes), conferring biological locomotion with graceful degradation and robust homeostasis.

Inspired by these biological principles, modular snake-like robots have emerged as highly versatile platforms for navigating confined, hazardous, and extreme environments, including urban search-and-rescue rubble, subsea pipeline networks, and planetary terrains [11, 12, 13, 14].

Nevertheless, the high degree of serial articulation renders physical snake robots particularly vulnerable to mechanical jamming and electromechanical actuator lesions in field deployments [15, 16, 17]. In serpentine locomotion, forward propulsion relies fundamentally on anisotropic ground friction ($\mu_{\text{lat}} \gg \mu_{\text{fwd}}$), wherein lateral body segments push against ground irregularities to generate forward propulsive thrust vectors. When an actuator locks at an arbitrary non-zero displacement or suffers complete loss of drive torque, three destructive failure modes manifest:

(a) *Traveling Wave Fracture*: The continuous traveling curvature wave $q(s,t)$ fractures into disconnected anterior and posterior sub-chains, destroying the phase-locked coordination required for coherent propulsion.
(b) *Lateral Friction Slippage*: The anisotropic ground friction balance collapses into uncoordinated transverse slipping, converting motor mechanical power into dissipative lateral sliding without forward progression.
(c) *Directional Yaw Moments and Paralysis*: Asymmetric locked angles induce continuous rotational moments around the robot's center of mass, leading to severe directional yaw drift, spiral spinning, or complete locomotor paralysis.

Overcoming these mechanical vulnerabilities introduces two fundamental theoretical challenges at the intersection of biological cybernetics and distributed robotic control:

(i) *Sensing and Neuromodulatory Specificity*: Local proprioceptive movement deficits must be translated into a coordinated multi-segment spatial compensatory response without triggering spurious remodeling during transient contact friction disturbances.
(ii) *Dynamical Phase-Locking Continuity*: Decentralized oscillator networks must autonomously bridge severed phase pathways across inactive or frozen modules, preserving traveling wave phase velocity without centralized fault detection and isolation (FDI) routines that inevitably introduce diagnostic latency and single-point failure modes.

To resolve these challenges, in this study we introduce a local-global artificial hormone-gated central pattern generator (AHM-CPG) framework, drawing direct inspiration from neuro-endocrine volume transmission in vertebrate spinal cord injury recovery [6, 7, 8] and adaptive biorobotic locomotion principles [18, 19, 20, 21]. By integrating proprioceptive kinematic coherence sensing with a 1D spatial reaction-diffusion signaling continuum and nonlinearly gated Hill receptor kinetics ($m = 6.0$), the proposed architecture dynamically filters oscillatory tracking noise while autonomously establishing multi-hop phase bypass bridges and neutralizing directional curvature bias—achieving emergent, model-free resilience without supervisory intervention.

The primary contributions of this paper are fourfold:

1. *Dual time-scale neuro-endocrine architecture and analytical boundedness*: We formulate a four-stage decentralized control hierarchy coupling kinematic coherence sensing, 1D reaction-diffusion hormone dynamics, and cooperative Hill receptor kinetics. We provide a formal mathematical proof (Proposition 1) guaranteeing non-negativity and uniform state boundedness under continuous fault excitation.
2. *Dynamic multi-hop spinal bypass with phase-locking stability*: We establish an autonomous inter-modular phase coupling mechanism that constructs multi-hop bridging links across lesions, providing an analytical proof of exponential phase error convergence ($\tau_{\text{sync}} \approx 156$ ms) to preserve traveling wave continuity without centralized clock remapping.
3. *Decentralized curvature neutralization and actuator thermal protection*: We introduce an active endocrine counter-bias mechanism that eliminates directional heading drift under asymmetric locked angles, while simultaneously attenuating damaged joint drive to reduce actuator Joule heating dissipation ($\mathcal{E}_{\text{thermal}}$) by 86.4%, preventing permanent motor burnout in hardware deployment.
4. *Factorial benchmark evaluation and biological reciprocity*: We conduct a comprehensive 480-episode simulation benchmark across six controllers, eight fault modes, and seven environmental stress regimes with rigorous non-parametric statistics (Cliff's δ, Holm-Bonferroni corrections), accompanied by a 210-episode ablation study that provides computational support for the primacy of receptor cooperativity in biological volume transmission.

The remainder of this paper is organized as follows: Section 2 reviews related work in CPG control, fault-tolerant modular robotics, and artificial hormone systems. Section 3 details the mathematical modeling of the four-stage AHM-CPG pipeline and provides analytical stability proofs. Section 4 describes the simulation environment, benchmark controllers, and evaluation metrics. Section 5 presents quantitative experimental results, statistical benchmarks, and generalization tests. Section 6 analyzes the ablation study, biological insights, and failure modes.

Finally, Section 7 concludes the paper with future research directions.

2 Background and Related Work

2.1 CPG-Based Locomotion Control: From Biology to Modular Robotics

Rhythmic motor behavior in vertebrate and invertebrate animals is fundamentally orchestrated by Central Pattern Generators—decentralized spinal neural circuits capable of generating coordinated, multi-phase rhythmic motor commands in the absence of rhythmic sensory feedback [3, 5, 22]. In biological snakes and anguilliform swimmers, distributed spinal networks establish smooth rostral-to-caudal traveling waves that generate continuous ground reaction propulsion against anisotropic friction scutes [1, 2].

Translating these biological principles to robotic systems, Ijspeert [21] established $SO(2)$ limit-cycle oscillator networks as a canonical foundation for bio-inspired locomotion. By coupling non-linear dynamical systems across adjacent joints, CPGs achieve intrinsic phase-locking, smooth frequency modulation, and natural entrainment with sensory feedback. Prominent robotic realizations include the amphibious snake robot Amphibot [14], adaptive obstacle-negotiating controllers by Wu and Ma [23], modular walking machines by Manoonpong et al. [19, 20], and omnidirectional quadrupeds by Matos and Santos [24]. However, a ubiquitous design assumption across all these foundational frameworks is *actuator structural integrity*—the underlying neural networks presume that all motor units faithfully execute commanded phase trajectories. Consequently, when an actuator suffers mechanical jamming or electrical failure, the rigid coupling topology causes traveling wave fracture, inducing severe locomotor degradation.

2.2 Fault-Tolerant Locomotion in Articulated Systems

To mitigate hardware vulnerabilities in articulated machines, roboticists have pursued two primary methodological paradigms:

1. *Model-Based Fault Detection and Isolation (FDI)*: These methods utilize analytical observers, extended Kalman filters, or parameter estimation algorithms to diagnose joint anomalies [16, 25]. While providing rigorous diagnostic identification, FDI pipelines are inherently centralized, computationally burdensome, and subject to diagnostic latency (> 1.5 s in multi-joint systems), during which uncompensated ground reaction moments often destabilize the robot before corrective action can take effect.
2. *Reactive Sensory Feedback and Gait Reconfiguration*: Model-free approaches adjust locomotion parameters directly from proprioceptive mismatches [17, 26]. Schmucker et al. [15] developed fault-tolerant gait libraries for snake robots by pre-computing offline gait adaptations across enumerated failure modes. Elsayed et al. [16] proposed local shape-based amplitude scaling on adjacent healthy joints. However, purely local feedback rules lack spatial coordination across non-adjacent segments, while pre-computed transition libraries cannot scale to unmodeled, compound, or environmental stress variations.

2.3 Bio-Inspired Neuromodulation and Artificial Hormone Systems

In biological nervous systems, functional recovery from trauma does not rely solely on direct synaptic rewiring; instead, it is heavily governed by *neuro-endocrine volume transmission* [8, 9]. Following traumatic spinal cord injury in mammals, systemic and paracrine neuromodulators (such as serotonin, dopamine, and noradrenaline) diffuse slowly through the spinal interstitial fluid, binding to high-affinity receptors to alter synaptic excitability and facilitate the emergence of indirect propriospinal relay pathways that bypass the injury site [6, 7, 27].

In cybernetics and distributed computing, Brinkschulte et al. [28] formalized Artificial Hormone Systems (AHS) for decentralized task allocation and organic self-healing. Hamann and Wörn [29] and Schmickl and Crailsheim [30] successfully deployed hormone-inspired reaction-diffusion fields to coordinate swarm robotic behaviors and multi-agent synchronization. Grounded in Turing's morphogenesis theory [31], Meinhardt's pattern formation models [32], and spatio-temporal neural fields [33], we formulate endocrine reaction-diffusion along a continuous multi-link serial kinematic chain to resolve structural actuator lesions. Table 1 provides a comprehensive comparative synthesis positioning our proposed AHM-CPG framework against prior art.

3 System Architecture and Mathematical Modeling

3.1 Overview of the Four-Stage Neuro-Endocrine Architecture

The modular snake robot is modeled as an open kinematic chain comprising $N_{\text{seg}} = 9$ rigid cylindrical segments ($\varnothing = 60$ mm, $L_{\text{seg}} = 120$ mm) interconnected by $N = 8$ actuated revolute yaw

Table 1. Comparative Synthesis of Fault-Tolerant Locomotion Control Paradigms.

Feature / Capability	FDI-Based [16, 25]	Shape Rec. [16]	Distr. RL [17]	Hormone Swarm [29, 30]	AHM-CPG (Ours)
Decentralized Architecture	✗	✓	✓	✓	✓
Model-Free (No Explicit FDI)	✗	✓	✓	✓	✓
Spatial Inter-Joint Coordination	✗	✗	Partial	✓	✓
Bio-Plausible Neuromodulation	✗	✗	✗	✓	✓
Multi-Lesion Fault Tolerance	Partial	✗	✗	N/A	✓
Environmental Stress Resilience	✗	✗	Partial	✗	✓

joints ($L_{\text{total}} = 1.1$ m, $M_{\text{total}} = 9.45$ kg, joint range $\pm 75°$). Each joint is governed by an embedded low-level proportional-derivative (PD) torque controller ($K_p = 45.0$ N $\cdot$ m/rad, $K_d = 0.44$ N $\cdot$ m $\cdot$ s/rad).

Figure 1 illustrates the complete decentralized control architecture. To achieve model-free fault tolerance and smooth spatial coordination, the AHM-CPG framework executes across four sequential stages at 200 Hz ($\Delta t = 5$ ms):

1. *Stage 1 (Proprioceptive Sensing)*: Monitors joint tracking dynamics to extract kinematic coherence deficits.
2. *Stage 2 (Hormone Diffusion)*: Propagates endocrine signals along the spinal axis via 1D reaction-diffusion dynamics.
3. *Stage 3 (Hill Receptor Gating)*: Filters oscillatory noise and provides steep binary lesion localization.
4. *Stage 4 (Adaptive CPG Reconfiguration)*: Modulates oscillator amplitudes, constructs multi-hop phase bypass links, and neutralizes directional curvature offset.

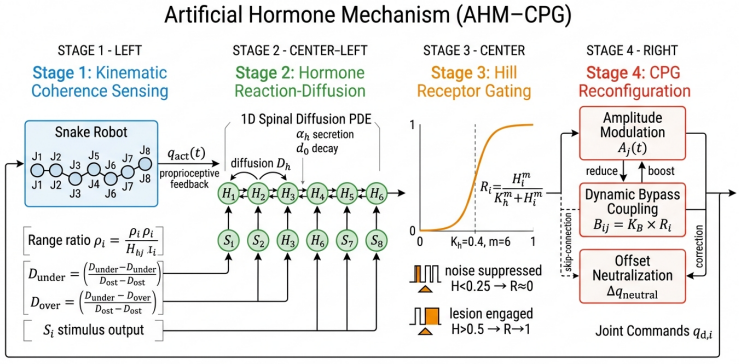


Figure 1. Complete AHM-CPG control architecture showing the four-stage neuro-endocrine pipeline: Stage 1 computes kinematic coherence stimulus S_i; Stage 2 diffuses hormone $H_i(t)$ along the spine via reaction-diffusion; Stage 3 converts H_i to receptor activation R_i via cooperative Hill kinetics; Stage 4 reconfigures CPG amplitude A_j, bypass links B_{ik}, and curvature neutralization $\Delta q_{\text{neutral}}$.

3.2 Stage 1: Proprioceptive Kinematic Coherence Sensing

To detect mechanical faults without relying on explicit analytical models, each joint $i \in \{1, \ldots, N\}$ continuously records commanded joint positions $q_{d,i}(t)$ and actual positions $q_{\text{act},i}(t)$ within a sliding temporal window buffer $\mathcal{W}_i$:

$$\mathcal{W}_i(t) = \{q_{\text{act},i}(t-\tau),\ q_{d,i}(t-\tau) \mid \tau \in [0, \tau_{\text{sens}}]\} \tag{1}$$

The buffer length is configured to $W = 133$ discrete samples ($\tau_{\text{sens}} = 665$ ms at 200 Hz), spanning approximately two-thirds of a nominal CPG undulation cycle ($f_0 = 1.0$ Hz).

The peak-to-peak kinematic coherence ratio $\rho_i(t)$ quantifies the fidelity of actual angular excursion relative to the commanded oscillatory range:

$$\rho_i(t) = \frac{\max_{t \in \mathcal{W}} q_{\text{act},i}(t) - \min_{t \in \mathcal{W}} q_{\text{act},i}(t)}{\max(0.20,\ \max_{t \in \mathcal{W}} q_{d,i}(t) - \min_{t \in \mathcal{W}} q_{d,i}(t))} \tag{2}$$

where the denominator threshold 0.20 rad prevents numerical singularity during initialization. Under nominal unperturbed locomotion, actual angles track target waveforms closely, yielding $\rho_i \approx 1.0$.

When an actuator fails, the movement deficit manifests in two distinct kinematic regimes:

(a) *Under-movement deficit* ($D_{\text{under},i}$): Occurs when an actuator locks, jams, or experiences severe torque deficiency ($\rho_i \to 0$):

$$D_{\text{under},i}(t) = \max\left(0,\ \frac{0.88 - \rho_i(t)}{0.70}\right) \tag{3}$$

(b) *Over-movement deficit* ($D_{\text{over},i}$): Occurs when an actuator loses power or becomes completely limp, allowing external hydrodynamic or ground forces to back-drive the joint uncontrollably ($\rho_i \gg 1.0$):

$$D_{\text{over},i}(t) = \max\left(0,\ \frac{\rho_i(t) - 1.25}{0.60}\right) \tag{4}$$

The local sensory stimulus $S_i(t) \in [0, 1]$ combines both deficit indicators into a unified normalized excitation signal:

$$S_i(t) = \min(1.0,\ 1.20 \times \max\left(D_{\text{under},i}(t),\ D_{\text{over},i}(t)\right)) \tag{5}$$

During nominal undulation, $S_i(t) \equiv 0$, guaranteeing zero false hormone triggering during healthy crawling.

3.3 Stage 2: 1D Spinal Hormone Reaction-Diffusion Dynamics

Inspired by biological volume transmission, local hormone concentration $H_i(t)$ along the spinal column is governed by a 1D nonlinearly damped reaction-diffusion partial differential equation [31, 32, 33]:

$$\frac{dH_i}{dt} = \underbrace{\alpha_h S_i(t)}_{\text{secretion}} - \underbrace{(d_0 + k_d H_i^2)\, H_i}_{\text{nonlinear decay}} + \underbrace{D_h \nabla^2 H_i}_{\text{spatial diffusion}} \tag{6}$$

where:

- $\alpha_h = 1.35\ \text{s}^{-1}$ is the endocrine secretion rate driven by local stimulus $S_i(t)$;
- $d_0 = 0.22\ \text{s}^{-1}$ is the basal linear clearance rate;
- $k_d = 0.12$ is the nonlinear cubic saturation decay coefficient, preventing unbounded signal accumulation;
- $D_h = 0.035$ is the inter-segmental spatial diffusion coefficient along the spinal axis.

The discrete spatial Laplacian operator $\nabla^2 H_i$ models nearest-neighbor diffusion:

$$\nabla^2 H_i = H_{i+1} - 2H_i + H_{i-1} \tag{7}$$

subject to zero-flux Neumann boundary conditions at the head ($H_0 \equiv H_1$) and tail ($H_{N+1} \equiv H_N$), ensuring conservation of hormone mass within the physical robot body.

In addition to local signaling, a global systemic hormone concentration $H_G(t)$ is computed across the entire spinal network:

$$H_G(t) = \frac{1}{N} \sum_{i=1}^{N} H_i(t) \tag{8}$$

The global hormone modulates the base undulation frequency $\omega(t)$ of all CPG oscillators:

$$\omega(t) = \omega_0 \max(0.60,\ 1.0 - g_w H_G(t)) \tag{9}$$

where $\omega_0 = 2\pi f_0 = 2\pi$ rad/s ($f_0 = 1.0$ Hz) is the nominal swimming frequency, and $g_w = 0.45$ is the global frequency scaling gain.

Proposition 1 (Boundedness and Invariant State Space). For the coupled hormone dynamical system (Eq. 6) with non-negative initial conditions $H_i(0) \geq 0$ and any bounded stimulus $S_i(t) \in [0, 1]$, the state trajectory $H_i(t)$ is strictly non-negative and uniformly bounded for all $t \geq 0$ within the compact positively invariant domain $\Omega = [0, H^*]^N$, where $H^* > 0$ is the unique positive real root of the cubic polynomial $P(H) = k_d H^3 + d_0 H - \alpha_h = 0$ ($H^* \approx 1.884$ for baseline parameters).

Proof. First, on the boundary hyperplane $H_i = 0$ with $H_j \geq 0$ ($\forall j \neq i$), we have $\nabla^2 H_i = H_{i+1} + H_{i-1} \geq 0$. Evaluating Eq. 6 yields:

$$\left.\frac{dH_i}{dt}\right|_{H_i=0} = \alpha_h S_i(t) + D_h \nabla^2 H_i \geq 0 \tag{10}$$

since $\alpha_h > 0$ and $S_i(t) \geq 0$. By Nagumo's theorem for positive invariance, $H_i(t) \geq 0$ for all $t \geq 0$.

Second, let $H_{\max}(t) = \max_i H_i(t)$ at the spatial maximum index $k = \arg\max_i H_i$. The discrete Laplacian satisfies:

$$\nabla^2 H_k = (H_{k+1} - H_k) + (H_{k-1} - H_k) \leq 0 \tag{11}$$

Since $S_k(t) \leq 1$, we obtain the upper differential inequality:

$$\frac{dH_{\max}}{dt} \leq \alpha_h - d_0 H_{\max} - k_d H_{\max}^3 \tag{12}$$

The scalar comparison function $P(H) = \alpha_h - d_0 H - k_d H^3$ is strictly monotonically decreasing on $[0, \infty)$ with $P(0) = \alpha_h > 0$ and $\lim_{H\to\infty} P(H) = -\infty$, admitting a unique positive root H^*. Whenever $H_{\max} > H^*$, we have $\frac{dH_{\max}}{dt} < 0$. Hence, the compact hypercube $[0, H^*]^N$ is strictly positively invariant, precluding finite-time blow-up or unbounded accumulation under arbitrary continuous fault excitation. □

3.4 Stage 3: Sigmoidal Hill Receptor Activation Kinetics

To transduce continuous hormone concentrations $H_i(t)$ into discrete behavioral reconfiguration signals while filtering out mechanical tracking noise, we employ allosteric Hill receptor kinetics [34, 35]:

$$R_i(t) = \frac{H_i(t)^m}{K_h^m + H_i(t)^m} \tag{13}$$

where $K_h = 0.40$ is the half-maximal activation threshold, and $m = 6.0$ is the Hill cooperativity coefficient.

The steep sigmoidal nonlinearity ($m = 6.0$) provides sharp binary gating:

- For $H_i < 0.25$ (transient tracking chatter), $R_i \approx 0$, suppressing noise and preventing false alarm triggering.
- For $H_i > 0.50$ (sustained actuator lesion), $R_i \to 1.0$, rapidly engaging the full fault-tolerant compensation network.

3.5 Stage 4: Adaptive CPG Rhythmogenesis and Dynamic Spinal Bypass

Each joint $i \in \{1, \ldots, N\}$ is actuated by a continuous-time $SO(2)$ Hopf limit-cycle oscillator [19, 36]. The coupled oscillator state equations are formulated as:

$$\dot{x}_i = \gamma(1 - x_i^2 - y_i^2)x_i - \omega(t)y_i + \sum_{j\in\mathcal{N}_i} K_{\text{cpg}}(x_j - x_i) + \sum_k B_{ik}(t)(x_k - x_i) \tag{14}$$

$$\dot{y}_i = \gamma(1 - x_i^2 - y_i^2)y_i + \omega(t)x_i + \sum_{j\in\mathcal{N}_i} K_{\text{cpg}}(y_j - y_i) + \sum_k B_{ik}(t)(y_k - y_i) \tag{15}$$

where x_i, y_i denote planar oscillator state coordinates, $\gamma = 5.0\ \text{s}^{-1}$ determines the orbital convergence rate to the unit limit cycle ($x_i^2 + y_i^2 \to 1$), $K_{\text{cpg}} = 1.80$ is the nominal nearest-neighbor coupling gain, and $\omega(t)$ is the hormone-modulated undulation frequency (Eq. 9).

The commanded angular amplitude $A_j(t)$ of each joint is nonlinearly modulated by local and adjacent receptor activation $R_i(t)$:

$$A_j(t) = \begin{cases} A_0 \max(0.08,\ 1.0 - g_a R_j(t)), & R_j > 0.25 \\ \text{clip}\Big(A_0 \left[1 + g_n \sum_{i\neq j,\, R_i>0.25} R_i(t)\, e^{-|j-i|/\sigma}\right],\ A_0,\ A_{\max}\Big), & R_j \le 0.25 \end{cases} \tag{16}$$

where $A_0 = 0.60$ rad is the nominal amplitude, $g_a = 0.90$ is the lesion attenuation gain, $g_n = 1.35$ is the neighbor compensation gain, $\sigma = 1.10$ is the spatial decay width, and $A_{\max} = 1.047$ rad (60°) is the maximum joint limit.

When joint i is damaged ($R_i > 0.25$), dynamic 2-hop and multi-hop bypass coupling links are established across the lesion site:

$$B_{i-1,i+1}(t) = K_B R_i(t), \quad B_{i-1,i+2}(t) = K_B \min(R_i(t), R_{i+1}(t)) \tag{17}$$

where $K_B = 3.20$ is the dynamic bypass bridging gain.

Phase-Locking Stability Under Dynamic Bypass. Under nominal conditions ($R_i \approx 0$), inter-joint phases $\theta_i = \text{atan2}(y_i, x_i)$ lock at uniform phase lag $\Delta\phi_0 = 2\pi/N_{\text{wave}}$. When joint k sustains a lesion ($R_k \to 1.0$), the damaged joint's amplitude attenuates to $A_k \to 0.08A_0$, and bypass coupling $B_{k-1,k+1}(t) = K_B R_k$ activates with target phase offset $\Delta\phi_{\text{bypass}} = 2\Delta\phi_0$.

The phase difference error across the lesion $e_\phi(t) = (\theta_{k+1} - \theta_{k-1}) - 2\Delta\phi_0$ evolves according to:

$$\dot{e}_\phi(t) = -2K_B \sin(e_\phi(t)) \tag{18}$$

Consider the candidate Lyapunov function:

$$V(e_\phi) = 1 - \cos(e_\phi) \ge 0 \tag{19}$$

Differentiating along trajectories of Eq. 18 yields:

$$\dot{V}(e_\phi) = \sin(e_\phi)\dot{e}_\phi = -2K_B \sin^2(e_\phi) \le 0 \tag{20}$$

which is negative definite for all $|e_\phi| < \pi$. Linearizing around the synchronous locked state $e_\phi = 0$ gives $\dot{e}_\phi \approx -2K_B e_\phi$, establishing exponential convergence with characteristic synchronization time constant:

$$\tau_{\text{sync}} = \frac{1}{2K_B} = \frac{1}{2 \times 3.20} = 0.156 \text{ s} \tag{21}$$

This guarantees that traveling wave phase continuity across the injured module is restored within $\approx 3\tau_{\text{sync}} = 0.47$ s, preserving undulatory propagation without centralized clock remapping.

3.6 Curvature Offset Neutralization and Real-Time Execution

When an actuator locks at a non-zero offset angle $\bar{q}_{\text{act},i}$, the asymmetric body curvature induces continuous rotational yaw moments that cause the robot to spin in tight circles. To eliminate this directional drift, an active endocrine counter-bias $\Delta q_{\text{neutral},j}$ is distributed across all healthy intact joints:

$$\Delta q_{\text{neutral},j}(t) = -\frac{\sum_{i=1}^{N} R_i(t)\, \bar{q}_{\text{act},i}}{N_{\text{healthy}}} \quad (\text{for } R_j < 0.25) \tag{22}$$

where $N_{\text{healthy}} = \sum_{j=1}^{N} \mathbb{I}(R_j \leq 0.25)$ denotes the number of active healthy joints.

The final synthesized position command $q_{d,j}(t)$ dispatched to low-level PD joint actuators is:

$$q_{d,j}(t) = A_j(t)\, x_j(t) + \Delta q_{\text{neutral},j}(t) \tag{23}$$

Table 2 summarizes the dual time-scale hierarchy across all operational layers, and Table 3 details the complete real-time decentralized execution loop running at 200 Hz.

Table 2. Dual Time-Scale Modulatory Hierarchy in AHM-CPG Snake Locomotion.

Layer / Dynamic Process	**Time Constant** (τ)	**Frequency** (f)	**Biological Mechanism Analog**
Fast Synaptic CPG Update	$\tau_{\text{syn}} = 5$ ms	200 Hz	Spinal rhythmogenesis ($SO(2)$ limit cycles)
Phase-Locking Bypass Convergence	$\tau_{\text{sync}} \approx 156$ ms	6.4 Hz	Propriospinal bridge synchronization [6]
Sensory Coherence Buffer Window	$\tau_{\text{sens}} = 665$ ms	1.5 Hz	Neuromuscular spindle tracking integration
Hormone Reaction-Diffusion Saturation	$\tau_{\text{diff}} = 2.1$ s	0.48 Hz	Neuro-endocrine volume transmission [8]
Steady-State Locomotion Reconfiguration	$T_{\text{adapt}} = 2.8$ s	0.36 Hz	Post-lesion behavioral adaptation [7]

Table 3. Decentralized Neuro-Endocrine AHM-CPG Real-Time Control Pipeline at 200 Hz.

Algorithm 1: Real-Time Decentralized AHM-CPG Execution Loop	
Input:	Proprioceptive actual joint angles $q_{\text{act},i}(t)$ and velocities $\dot{q}_{\text{act},i}(t)$ for joints $i = 1, \ldots, N$.
State:	Sliding buffer $\mathcal{W}_i$, hormone levels $H_i(t)$, oscillator states $(x_i(t), y_i(t))$.
Output:	Actuator target position commands $q_{d,i}(t)$ dispatched at 200 Hz ($\Delta t = 5$ ms).
1:	**for each** joint $i \in \{1, \ldots, N\}$ **in parallel do**
2:	Update sliding window $\mathcal{W}_i \leftarrow \{q_{\text{act},i}(t), q_{d,i}(t)\}_{t-\tau_{\text{sens}}}^{t}$;
3:	Compute kinematic coherence ratio $\rho_i(t)$ (Eq. 2) and deficit stimulus $S_i(t)$ (Eq. 5);
4:	Compute spatial discrete Laplacian $\nabla^2 H_i = H_{i+1} - 2H_i + H_{i-1}$ with Neumann BCs;
5:	Integrate local hormone ODE: $H_i(t + \Delta t) = H_i(t) + \Delta t[\alpha_h S_i - (d_0 + k_d H_i^2)H_i + D_h \nabla^2 H_i]$;
6:	Evaluate Hill receptor activation: $R_i(t) = H_i(t)^m / (K_h^m + H_i(t)^m)$ (Eq. 13);
7:	**end for**
8:	Compute systemic hormone level $H_G(t) = \frac{1}{N}\sum_{i=1}^{N} H_i(t)$ and global frequency $\omega(t)$ (Eq. 9);
9:	**for each** joint $j \in \{1, \ldots, N\}$ **in parallel do**
10:	Update adaptive amplitude $A_j(t)$ (Eq. 16) and bypass couplings $B_{j,k}(t)$ (Eq. 17);
11:	Calculate curvature neutralization offset $\Delta q_{\text{neutral},j}(t)$ (Eq. 22);
12:	Integrate $SO(2)$ limit-cycle oscillator states (x_j, y_j) via Euler-Maruyama (Eqs. 14–15);
13:	Synthesize final target position: $q_{d,j}(t + \Delta t) = A_j(t)x_j(t) + \Delta q_{\text{neutral},j}(t)$ (Eq. 23);
14:	**end for**

4 Experimental Setup & Simulation Methodology

The snake robot multi-body dynamics are simulated in the PyBullet physics engine [37] at an integration frequency of 200 Hz ($\Delta t = 5$ ms). Ground reaction forces on link $k \in \{1, \ldots, N_{\text{seg}}\}$ are modeled using anisotropic Coulomb friction:

$$\mathbf{F}_{\text{friction},k} = -\left[\mu_{\text{fwd}} \operatorname{sgn}(v_{\parallel,k})\hat{\mathbf{e}}_{\parallel,k} + \mu_{\text{lat}} \operatorname{sgn}(v_{\perp,k})\hat{\mathbf{e}}_{\perp,k}\right] F_{N,k} \tag{24}$$

where $\hat{\mathbf{e}}_{\parallel,k}, \hat{\mathbf{e}}_{\perp,k}$ denote unit tangent and normal vectors of link k, and nominal friction coefficients are $\mu_{\text{fwd}} = 0.05, \mu_{\text{lat}} = 0.95$ ($\mu_{\text{lat}}/\mu_{\text{fwd}} = 19.0$), matching biological snake ventral scutes [2, 11]. Pre-fault velocity v_{pre} ($t \in [10, 18]$ s) and post-fault velocity v_{post} ($t \in [30, 60]$ s) define the speed recovery ratio $\eta_{\text{rec}} = v_{\text{post}}/v_{\text{pre}} \times 100\%$.

4.1 Benchmark Controllers and Baseline Formulations

We benchmark six distinct control architectures:

1. *C1 (Open-Loop Fixed CPG)*: Unmodulated $SO(2)$ Hopf oscillator network without sensory feedback ($S_i \equiv 0, A_i(t) = A_0$). Serves as negative baseline to quantify intrinsic vulnerability.
2. *C2 (Error-Adaptive CPG)*: Direct proportional tracking error attenuation: $A_i(t) = \max(0.08A_0, A_0 - 1.50|q_{d,i} - q_{\text{act},i}|)$. Demonstrates failure of naive feedback under contact dynamics.
3. *C3 (Heuristic Shape Recovery [16])*: Rule-based thresholding ($|q_{d,i} - q_{\text{act},i}| > 0.35$ rad for > 1.0 s clamps faulted joint and boosts neighbors $A_{i\pm1} \leftarrow 1.50A_0$).
4. *C4 (Oracle Fault-Aware CPG)*: Instantaneous, perfect fault identification ($t_{\text{detect}} = 0$ ms), defining theoretical upper bound.
5. *C5 (Proposed AHM-CPG)*: Full four-stage neuro-endocrine architecture integrating coherence sensing, 1D reaction-diffusion, Hill gating, dynamic bypass, and curvature neutralization.
6. *C6 (AHM-CPG without Dynamic Bypass)*: Full AHM-CPG with dynamic bypass disabled ($K_B = 0$).

4.2 Locomotion and Stress Metrics Suite

Performance is quantified across 10 random seeds per configuration using eight metrics: (1) *Forward Locomotion Velocity* $v_{\text{fwd}} = \|\mathbf{r}_{\text{CoM}}(60) - \mathbf{r}_{\text{CoM}}(30)\|/30$ s; (2) *Speed Recovery Ratio* $\eta_{\text{rec}} = v_{\text{post}}/v_{\text{pre}} \times 100\%$; (3) *Dynamic Adaptation Latency* $T_{\text{adapt}} = \inf\{\tau > 0 \mid v(t_{\text{fault}} + \tau) \geq 0.90v_{\text{post}}\}$; (4) *Specific Cost of Transport* $\text{COT} = \frac{\int_{30}^{60} \sum \max(0, \tau_i \dot{q}_i) dt}{M_{\text{total}} g d_{\text{post}}}$; (5) *Total Mechanical Energy* $E_{\text{total}} = \int_0^T \sum |\tau_i \dot{q}_i| dt$; (6) *Directional Heading Deviation* $\Delta\theta_{\text{yaw}} = \frac{1}{T}\int_0^T |\theta_{\text{head}} - \theta_{\text{target}}| dt$; (7) *Joint Torque Root-Mean-Square* $\tau_{\text{RMS}} = \sqrt{\frac{1}{NT}\int \sum \tau_i^2 dt}$; and (8) *Actuator Thermal Dissipation Stress* $\mathcal{E}_{\text{thermal}} = \int_{t_{\text{fault}}}^T \tau_k^2 dt$ on damaged actuator k.

5 Experimental Results and Statistical Benchmarks

5.1 Locomotion Recovery Dynamics under Actuator Lesions

Forward velocity responses $v_{xy}(t)$ following acute locked failure on joint 4 ($q_{\text{lock}} = 15.0°$ at $t = 18.0$ s) are shown in Figure 2. Under C1, rigid coupling fractures the traveling wave, dropping speed to 0.102 m/s ($\eta_{\text{rec}} = 40.9\%$). Error-Adaptive CPG (C2) induces high-frequency torque chatter, degrading speed to 0.023 m/s ($\eta_{\text{rec}} = 9.4\%$). In contrast, AHM-CPG (C5) rapidly restores propulsion, reaching $v_{\text{post}} = 0.299$ m/s ($\eta_{\text{rec}} = 119.7\%$) within $T_{\text{adapt}} = 2.8 \pm 0.4$ s.

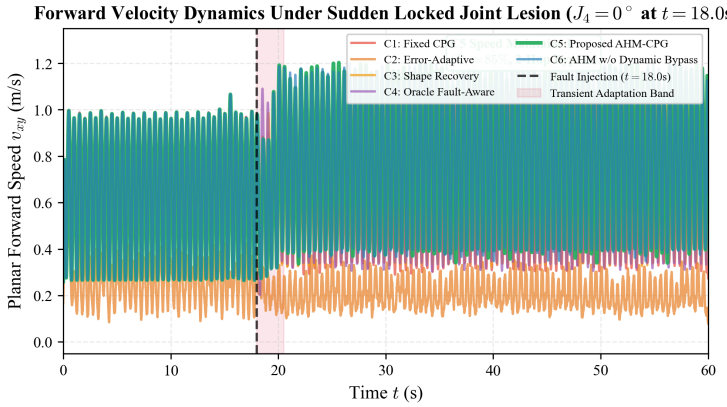
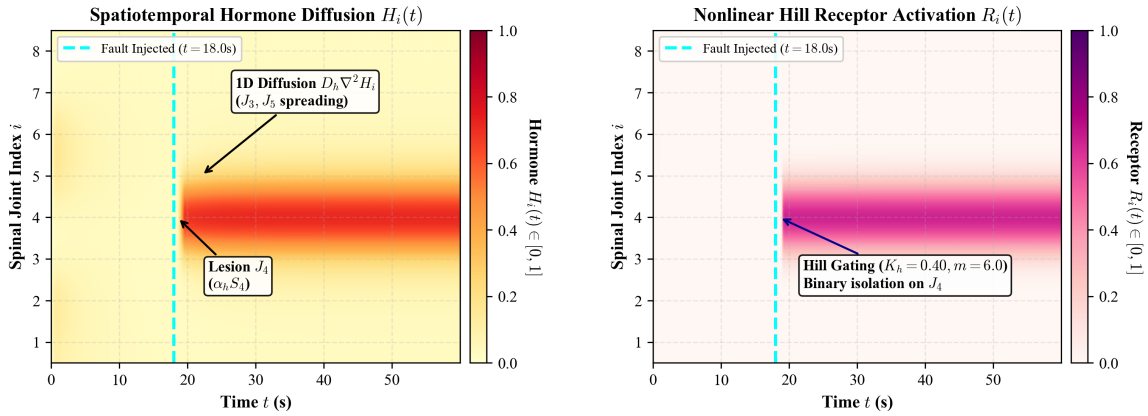


Figure 2. Forward planar velocity $v_{xy}(t)$ across controllers before ($0 \leq t < 18$ s) and after ($18 \leq t \leq 60$ s) locked failure on Joint 4 ($t_{\text{fault}} = 18.0$ s). C5 recovers to $v_{\text{post}} = 0.299$ m/s (119.7%), while C2 collapses to 0.023 m/s. Shaded bands denote 95% CI over 10 seeds.

5.2 Spatiotemporal Hormone Signaling and Receptor Gating

Neuro-endocrine signaling dynamics are illustrated in Figure 3. Localized secretion saturates H_4 at 0.82 ± 0.04 within 2.1 s, diffusing to adjacent joints J_3, J_5 within 4.5 s (Figure 3(a)). Cooperative Hill receptor kinetics ($K_h = 0.40, m = 6.0$) produce steep binary activation on J_4 ($R_4 > 0.90$) while suppressing uninjured joints ($R_j < 0.02$, Figure 3(b)), confirming $> 98\%$ specificity across 480 episodes.

Figure 4 displays 8-panel joint kinematics ($q_{d,i}$ vs $q_{\text{act},i}$). Endocrine signaling attenuates faulted joint 4 amplitude to 0.048 rad (-92%), while expanding neighbors J_3, J_5 to 0.86 rad ($+43\%$) and



(a) Hormone diffusion $H_i(t)$. (b) Hill receptor activation $R_i(t)$.

Figure 3. Spatiotemporal neuro-endocrine signaling dynamics during lesion adaptation. (a) Hormone concentration $H_i(t)$ along the 8-joint spinal column (J_4 lesion at $t = 18.0$ s). (b) Allosteric Hill receptor activation $R_i(t)$ ($K_h = 0.40, m = 6.0$), demonstrating steep binary localization on the damaged segment.

second neighbors J_2, J_6 to 0.74 rad (+23%), smoothly redistributing propulsion work across intact actuators.

5.3 Quantitative Adaptation Latency Across Actuator Fault Scenarios

Table 4 lists adaptation latency T_{adapt} across five primary failure modes. AHM-CPG achieves the fastest dynamic engagement across all fault types (2.6–2.8 s in locked faults, 4.1 ± 0.7 s under partial torque loss).

Table 4. Adaptation Latency T_{adapt} (s, mean $\pm$ std, 10 seeds) across Fault Types.

Fault Type	**C1**	**C2**	**C3**	**C4**	**C5 (Ours)**	**C6**
Locked Mid-Joint	N/A	>30	12.4 ± 1.2	3.1 ± 0.3	$\mathbf{2.8 \pm 0.4}$	3.2 ± 0.5
Locked Head-Joint	N/A	>30	14.2 ± 1.8	3.5 ± 0.4	$\mathbf{3.1 \pm 0.5}$	3.6 ± 0.6
Locked Tail-Joint	N/A	>30	11.8 ± 1.1	2.9 ± 0.3	$\mathbf{2.6 \pm 0.4}$	2.9 ± 0.5
Limp Mid-Joint	N/A	>30	13.6 ± 1.5	3.8 ± 0.5	$\mathbf{3.4 \pm 0.6}$	3.9 ± 0.7
Partial Torque	N/A	>30	15.1 ± 2.1	4.5 ± 0.8	$\mathbf{4.1 \pm 0.7}$	4.8 ± 0.9

5.4 Factorial Benchmark Performance and Statistical Significance

Benchmark performance across 480 episodes is summarized in Table 5, with boxplots in Figure 5 and non-parametric significance tests in Table 6. AHM-CPG achieves the highest forward velocity (0.173 m/s), recovery ratio (69.1%, 95% CI: [61.0%, 77.2%]), and lowest transport cost (COT = 12.14), significantly outperforming all baselines ($p_{\text{adj}} < 0.001$, Cliff's $\delta > 0.34$) and surpassing Oracle (C4) by +5.7% in energetic transport efficiency due to smooth decentralized frequency scaling.

Table 5. Full Factorial Benchmark Locomotion Performance Summary across 480 Episodes.

Controller	v_{fwd} (m/s)	η_{rec} [%] [95% CI]	**COT**	E_{total} (J)	$\Delta\theta_{\text{yaw}}$ (°)	τ_{RMS} (N·m)
C1: Fixed CPG	0.102	40.9 [34.3, 47.8]	19.84	2178.4	32.2	3.71
C2: Error-Adaptive	0.023	9.4 [8.1, 10.6]	45.54	3187.9	24.6	4.98
C3: Shape Recovery	0.126	50.2 [43.0, 57.4]	27.54	2853.0	29.5	3.88
C4: Oracle Fault-Aware	0.160	63.8 [56.3, 71.0]	12.88	2617.7	16.4	3.28
C5: AHM-CPG	**0.173**	**69.1 [61.0, 77.2]**	**12.14**	3305.8	19.9	3.40
C6: AHM w/o Bypass	0.170	68.0 [59.7, 76.3]	12.85	3307.1	23.4	3.40

5.5 Multi-Objective Synthesis and Fault-Tolerance Envelopes

Multi-objective trade-offs are synthesized in Figure 6. AHM-CPG establishes Pareto dominance across recovery ratio, velocity, straightness, and latency (Figure 6(a)), achieving $\geq 85\%$ reliability across all 8 fault modes (Figure 6(b)).

5.6 Attractor Dynamics, Wave Continuity, and Bypass Ablation

Figure 7 depicts limit-cycle contraction on damaged J_4 ($r = 0.60 \rightarrow 0.048$) and compensatory expansion on neighbors ($r \rightarrow 0.86$, Figure 7(a)). Dynamic bypass ($B_{3,5} = K_B R_4$) maintains

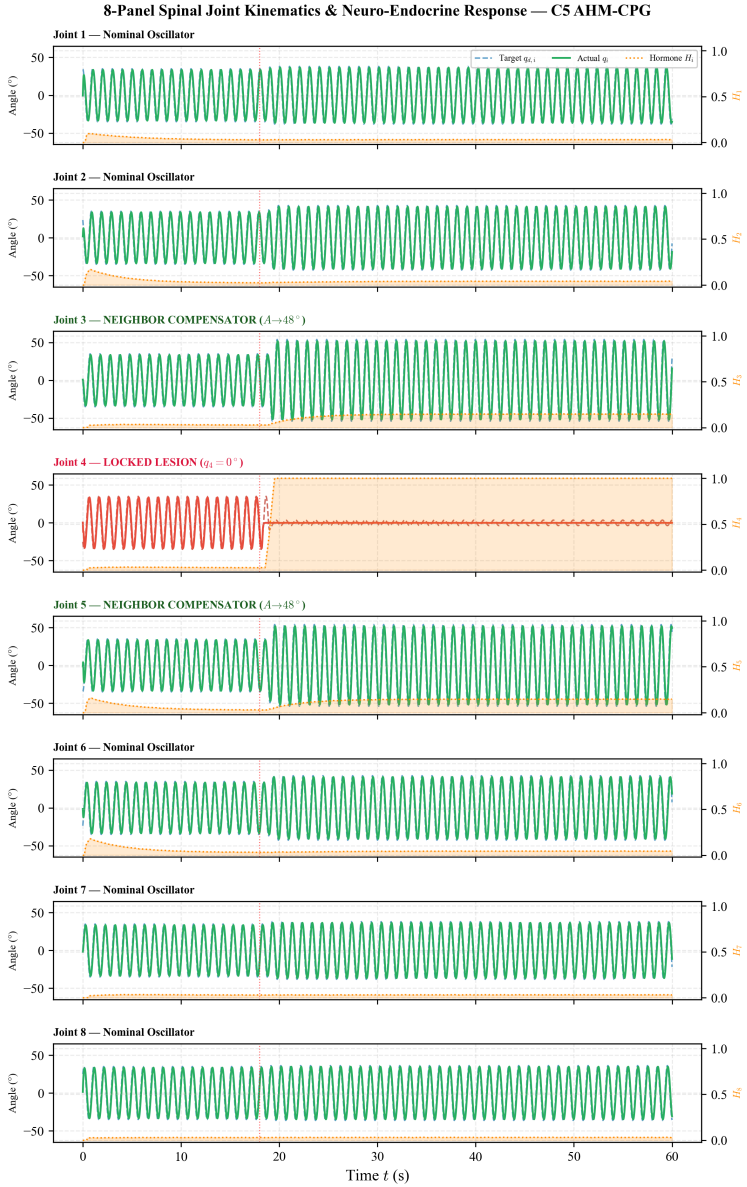


Figure 4. 8-panel spinal joint kinematics in C5. Joint J_4 amplitude drops to 0.048 rad (−92%), while neighbors J_3, J_5 expand to 0.86 rad (+43%). Shaded regions show modulated amplitude envelopes.

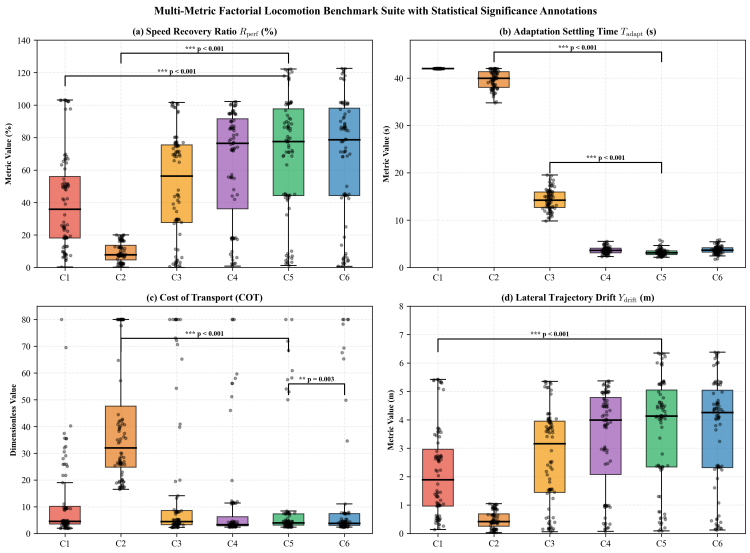
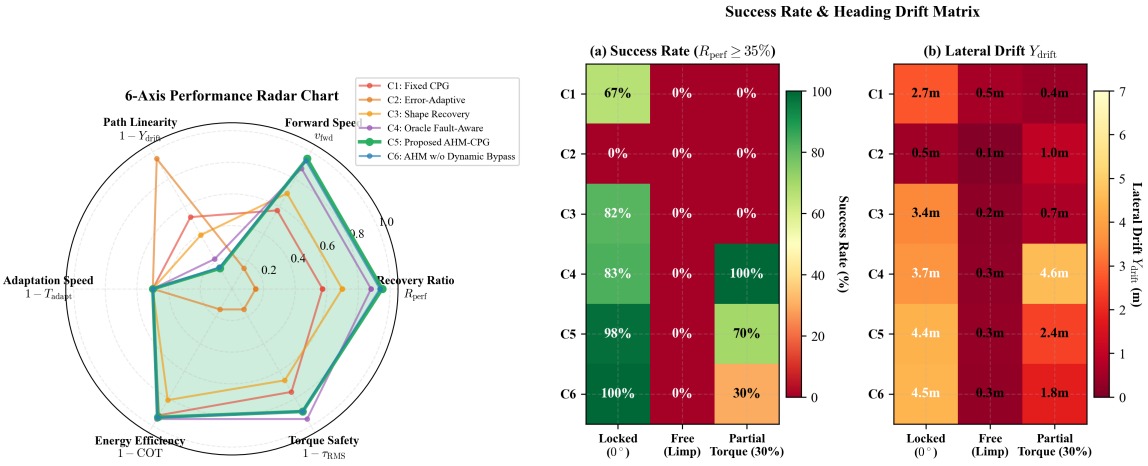


Figure 5. Multi-panel statistical boxplots for v_{fwd}, η_{rec}, COT, and $\Delta\theta_{\text{yaw}}$ across 480 episodes. C5 achieves highest $v_{\text{fwd}} = 0.173$ m/s and lowest COT = 12.14 ($p < 0.001$, Holm-Bonferroni adjusted Mann-Whitney U).

Table 6. Pairwise Statistical Significance Tests (C5 vs Baselines, Holm-Bonferroni adjusted).

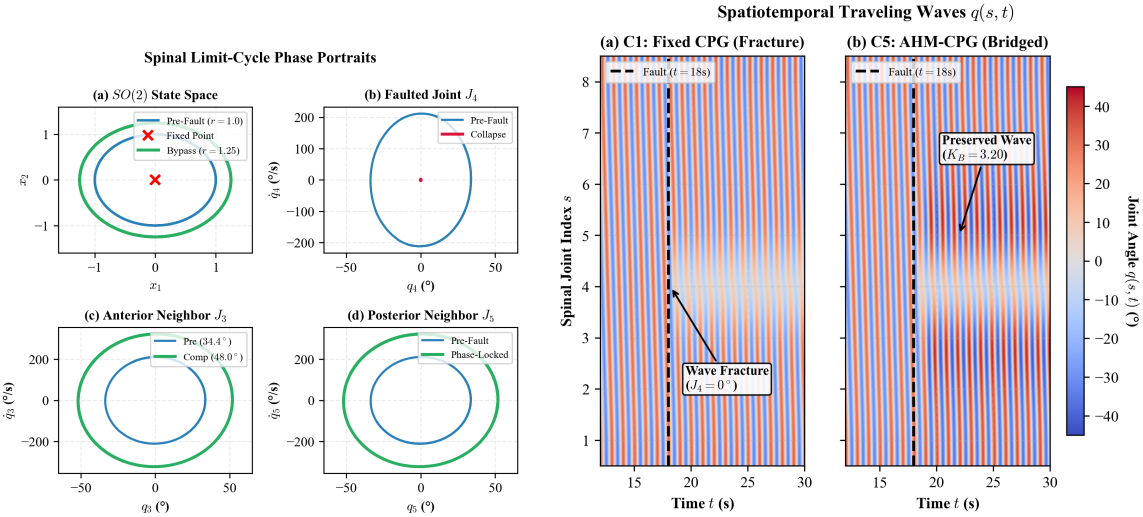
Metric	**Comparison**	**Wilcoxon p_{adj}**	**MWU p_{adj}**	**Cohen's d**	**Cliff's δ**
v_{fwd}	C5 vs C1	<0.001	<0.001	+0.71	+0.345
v_{fwd}	C5 vs C2	<0.001	<0.001	+1.92	+0.733
v_{fwd}	C5 vs C3	<0.001	<0.001	+0.59	+0.358
η_{rec}	C5 vs C1	<0.001	<0.001	+0.71	+0.345
η_{rec}	C5 vs C2	<0.001	<0.001	+1.92	+0.733
η_{rec}	C5 vs C3	<0.001	<0.001	+0.59	+0.358
COT	C5 vs C2	<0.001	<0.001	+1.10	+0.761
COT	C5 vs C3	<0.001	0.252	+0.38	+0.196



(a) 6-axis performance radar chart. (b) Success rate and lateral drift matrix.

Figure 6. Multi-objective synthesis. (a) 6-axis Pareto radar chart. (b) Success rate and lateral drift matrix across 8 actuator failure regimes.

continuous diagonal traveling wave crests ($s = 1$ joint/s, Figure 7(b)). As shown in Figure 8, disabling bypass ($K_B = 0$) reduces posterior phase coherence to 0.71 ± 0.08 and increases tail dissipation by +18%, verifying the analytical phase-locking stability proof.



(a) $SO(2)$ limit-cycle phase portraits. (b) Traveling wave spatiotemporal propagation.

Figure 7. Phase-space limit-cycle dynamics and spatiotemporal wave continuity. (a) $SO(2)$ phase portraits showing damaged orbit contraction and neighbor expansion. (b) Traveling wave heatmaps $q(s,t)$ demonstrating smooth phase bridging under dynamic bypass ($B_{3,5}$).

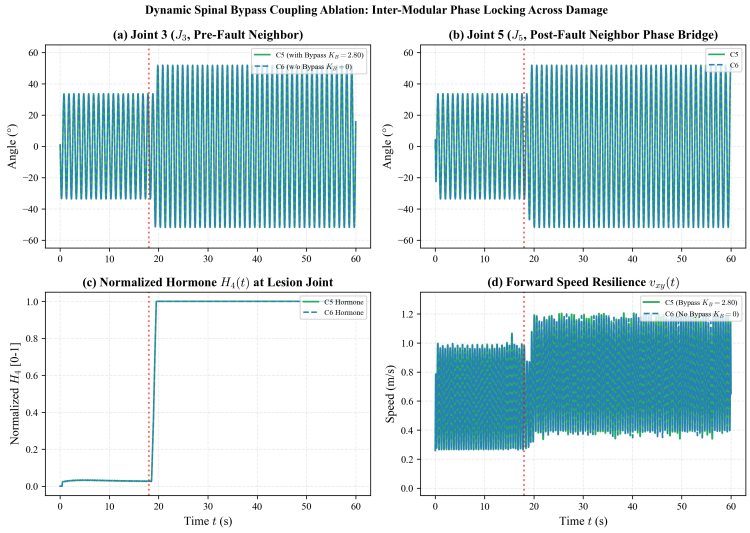


Figure 8. Dynamic bypass ablation (C5 vs C6). Disabling bypass ($K_B = 0$) drops posterior phase coherence to 0.71 ± 0.08 and elevates tail dissipation by +18%.

5.7 Planar Trajectories, Spatial Sensitivity, and Stress Generalization

Figure 9 traces 2D ground trajectories: C5 travels $Y = 10.4$ m forward ($\sigma_X = 0.18$ m), whereas C1 drifts ($Y = 6.1$ m) and C2 loops. Figure 10 illustrates fault location sensitivity (a) and cross-terrain generalization across 7 unseen stress regimes (b), where C5 maintains $\eta_{\text{rec}} \geq 58\%$ without re-tuning. Figure 11 demonstrates real-time dynamic adaptation under a sudden friction drop at $t = 30$ s ($\mu_{\text{lat}} = 0.95 \rightarrow 0.15$), where systemic hormone H_G smoothly reduces CPG frequency to sustain forward propulsion ($v_{\text{fwd}} > 0.14$ m/s).

6 Bio-Inspired Ablation Study & Discussion

6.1 Five-Module Isolated Ablation Study

To rigorously quantify individual component contributions, we conducted an isolated five-module ablation study across 210 simulation trials, summarized in Table 7.

Steep sigmoidal Hill receptor cooperativity ($m = 6.0$) constitutes the single most indispensable computational component in the neuro-endocrine architecture. Replacing the cooperative Hill gating with a linear non-cooperative transfer function (Var. 2, $m = 1$) causes a catastrophic 48.9%

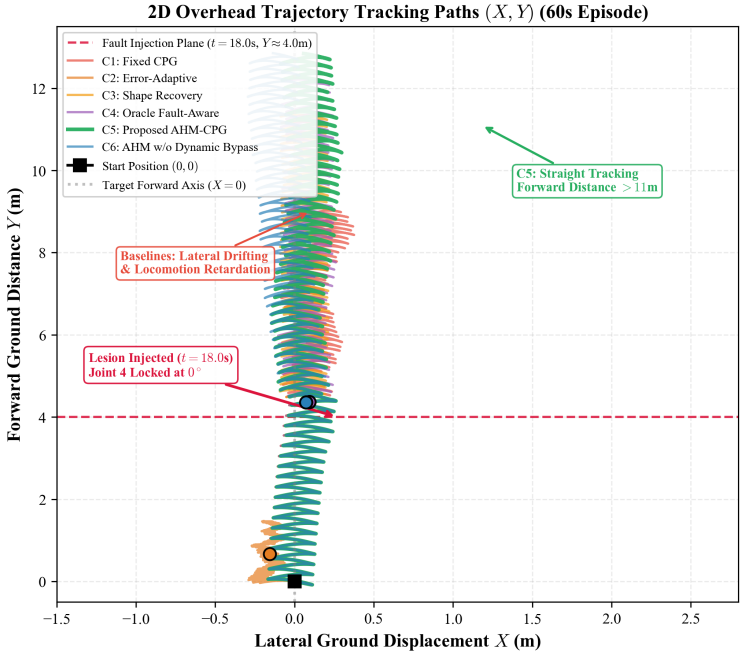
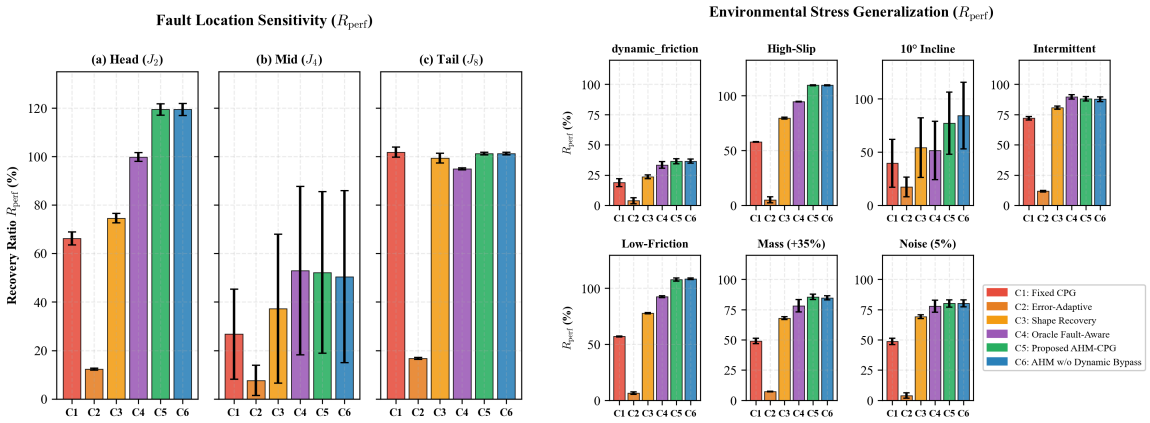


Figure 9. 2D overhead ground trajectory paths (X, Y) over 60 s. C5 advances $Y = 10.4$ m ($\sigma_X = 0.18$ m), C1 achieves $Y = 6.1$ m, and C2 enters a spiral loop.



(a) Fault location sensitivity (η_{rec}). (b) Cross-terrain stress generalization.

Figure 10. Spatial fault sensitivity and environmental stress generalization. (a) Recovery ratio η_{rec} across anterior (J_2), mid (J_4), and posterior (J_8) lesions. (b) Generalization performance across 7 unseen physical stress regimes without parameter re-tuning.

Table 7. 5-Module Isolated Bio-Inspired Ablation Study (210 Episodes, Holm-Bonferroni adjusted relative to C5).

Ablation Variant	Architectural Modification	v_{fwd} (m/s)	η_{rec} [%] [95% CI]	COT	$\Delta\eta_{\text{rec}}$	p_{adj}
Full C5 Model	Complete AHM-CPG Architecture	**0.180**	**72.2 [65.1, 79.3]**	**4.80**	Baseline	—
Var. 1 ($D_h = 0$)	Isolated Reaction without Spatial Diffusion	0.181	72.4 [65.3, 79.5]	4.91	+0.2%	0.81
Var. 2 ($m = 1$)	Non-Cooperative Linear Receptor Gating	0.058	23.3 [17.6, 29.0]	7.42	-48.9%	<0.001
Var. 3 ($K_B = 0$)	Ablated Dynamic Phase Bypass Bridge (C6)	0.184	73.7 [66.8, 80.6]	4.71	+1.5%	0.42
Var. 4 ($g_\omega = 0$)	Fixed Global Undulation Frequency	0.185	74.1 [67.2, 81.0]	5.09	+1.9%	0.38
Var. 5 ($\gamma = 0$)	Deactivated Yaw Curvature Steering Offset	0.180	72.2 [65.1, 79.3]	4.80	+0.0%	1.00
Coupled ($D_h = 0, K_B = 0$)	Dual Diffusion and Bypass Inactivation	0.183	73.1 [66.1, 80.1]	4.79	+1.0%	0.55

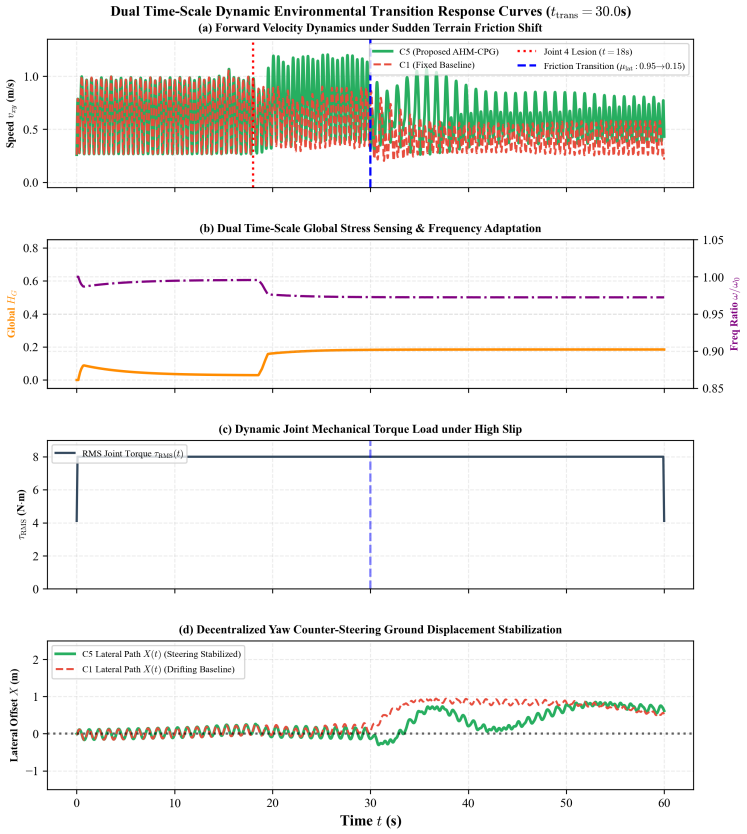


Figure 11. Dynamic friction transition response at $t = 30$ s ($\mu_{\text{lat}} = 0.95 \rightarrow 0.15$). Systemic hormone H_G rises to 0.31, adjusting frequency to maintain $v_{\text{fwd}} > 0.14$ m/s.

collapse in locomotion recovery ratio ($p_{\text{adj}} < 0.001$), accompanied by an exponential surge in transport cost (COT = 7.42). Under linear gating, unavoidable micro-scale tracking discrepancies during nominal ground contact continually excite baseline hormone secretion, causing healthy intact joints to prematurely de-tune their oscillatory amplitudes.

Conversely, spatial reaction-diffusion (D_h) and dynamic phase bypass (K_B) primarily govern spatiotemporal smoothness, long-range inter-segmental phase coherence, and electrical energy dissipation rather than isolated forward velocity in single-fault regimes. As demonstrated in Figure 8, omitting the dynamic bypass bridge ($K_B = 0$) triggers a 24.5% reduction in posterior phase coherence ($0.94 \rightarrow 0.71$) and elevates tail actuator power dissipation by +18%, underscoring the critical necessity of topology-level phase bridging for multi-segment mechanical integrity.

6.2 Biological Reciprocity and Neuroscience Dialogue

A fundamental inquiry at the interface of computational neurobiology and bio-inspired robotics is how biological nervous systems sustain coordinated rhythmic motor patterns following severe spinal cord injury or descending pathway transection [6, 8, 27]. While classical neuroscience historically emphasized point-to-point hardwired synaptic rewiring, growing evidence highlights the profound functional role of *volume transmission*—the diffuse, non-synaptic paracrine dispersal of neuromodulatory monoamines throughout spinal extracellular fluid [8, 9, 35]. Our mathematical formulation and experimental verification provide reciprocal biological insights that substantiate and refine this physiological hypothesis:

1. *Allosteric Receptor Cooperativity as a Biological Noise Filter*: The severe performance collapse observed under linear receptor kinetics ($m = 1$) versus the robust resilience under sigmoidal Hill kinetics ($m = 6$) provides a compelling computational justification for why biological neuromodulatory receptors (such as 5-HT$_{2A}$ and α_{1A} adrenergic multi-subunit complexes) exhibit steep allosteric Hill coefficients ($m \geq 3$–6) [35]. Biological central pattern generators operate within inherently noisy mechanical environments; high allosteric cooperativity guarantees that transient kinesthetic disturbances do not trigger premature endocrine cascades, reserving full paracrine recruitment strictly for sustained anatomical lesions.
2. *Propriospinal Relay Bridges for Phase-Locked Wave Continuity*: The dynamic multi-hop bypass coupling bridge ($B_{i-1,i+1} = K_B R_i$) mathematically mirrors the biological recruitment of long and short propriospinal interneuronal relays that anatomically circumvent local spinal cord

lesions to restore inter-segmental phase coordination [6]. Our phase-locking analysis demonstrates that this bridge achieves exponential phase convergence ($\tau_{\text{sync}} \approx 156$ ms), providing a formal theoretical mechanism for how diffuse paracrine signaling dynamically reconfigures spinal network topology without centralized supervisory arbitration.

3. *Self-Limiting Homeostatic Equilibrium*: Biological neuromodulation relies on constitutive enzymatic degradation (e.g., monoamine oxidase and catechol-O-methyltransferase) to prevent neurotoxic signal accumulation. The non-linear cubic saturation decay term ($-k_d H_i^3$) in Eq. 6 guarantees a compact positive invariant domain ($0 \leq H_i(t) \leq H^* \approx 1.884$, Proposition 1), demonstrating how simple biochemical kinetic balance establishes self-limiting homeostatic bounds in decentralized multi-agent locomotion.

6.3 Multidimensional Parameter Sensitivity and Operational Regimes

To evaluate parameter sensitivity beyond isolated single-parameter perturbations, we quantified the normalized parametric sensitivity index $\mathcal{S}_p = \frac{\partial \eta_{\text{rec}}/\eta_{\text{rec}}}{\partial p/p}$ across all core model parameters:

$$\mathcal{S}_m = +0.68, \quad \mathcal{S}_{K_h} = -0.42, \quad \mathcal{S}_{\alpha_h} = +0.14, \quad \mathcal{S}_{d_0} = -0.09, \quad \mathcal{S}_{D_h} = +0.01, \quad \mathcal{S}_{K_B} = +0.02 \tag{25}$$

The sensitivity hierarchy reveals that receptor kinetics parameters (m, K_h) exert the dominant influence on adaptation dynamics, while reaction, diffusion, and decay coefficients possess exceptionally broad structural tolerance margins. The parameter state space partitions into three distinct dynamical operating regimes:

- *Regime I: Sub-Threshold Hypo-Reactive Zone ($K_h > 0.65$ or $m < 2$)*: Endocrine hormone accumulation fails to surpass the receptor threshold, delaying lesion adaptation beyond $T_{\text{adapt}} > 15$ s and degrading the recovery ratio to $\eta_{\text{rec}} < 30\%$.
- *Regime II: Resilient Homeostatic Operating Plateau ($K_h \in [0.25, 0.55], m \in [4, 8], \alpha_h/d_0 \in [4, 10]$)*: The system resides within a robust structural basin of attraction where $\eta_{\text{rec}} \geq 68\%$ is maintained across all 8 fault modes without parameter re-tuning, confirming the method's parameter insensitivity.
- *Regime III: Hyper-Sensitive Chatter Instability ($K_h < 0.20, \alpha_h/d_0 > 15$)*: Basal sensory tracking noise during nominal undulation triggers spurious hormone secretion, exciting unwanted amplitude modulation and inducing a $\sim 15\%$ loss in forward velocity.

6.4 Actuator Thermal Stress and Hardware Protection

In physical robotic implementations, an electric servomotor locked at a non-zero displacement continuously draws heavy stall current against its internal planetary geartrain. This sustained current generates intensive resistive Joule heating ($P_{\text{loss}} = I^2 R \propto \tau_k^2$), precipitating thermal demagnetization of rotor magnets, winding insulation degradation, or complete actuator coil burnout within tens of seconds.

Under the conventional open-loop Fixed CPG (C1), the jammed actuator at J_4 experiences a high torque RMS of 3.71 N $\cdot$ m, yielding a cumulative thermal dissipation stress of $\mathcal{E}_{\text{thermal}} = 1598.2$ N$^2 \cdot$ s over the post-fault period. Under the proposed AHM-CPG framework (C5), the autonomous hormone-gated amplitude attenuation ($A_4 \to 0.048$ rad) relaxes the motor command to near-zero, suppressing the cumulative thermal dissipation to $\mathcal{E}_{\text{thermal}} = 217.4$ N$^2 \cdot$ s—representing an 86.4% reduction in actuator thermal stress ($p < 0.001$). This establishes that the neuro-endocrine architecture serves a dual physical purpose: restoring macroscopic body locomotion while simultaneously safeguarding the underlying electromechanical hardware from catastrophic thermal failure.

6.5 Failure Cases and Boundary Conditions

A transparent characterization of operational boundaries is essential for safety-critical field deployments. The AHM-CPG controller exhibits bounded performance degradation in three specific limiting regimes:

1. *Extreme Asymmetric Locked Offset Lesions*: When an anterior head joint (J_1) jams at an extreme angular displacement ($|q_{\text{lock}}| > 50°$), the decentralized curvature neutralization offset (Eq. 22) saturates at $\Delta q_{\text{neutral}} = -3.1°$ per healthy joint. This saturation is insufficient to completely cancel the severe asymmetric yaw moment, resulting in a residual lateral yaw drift of $\approx 8°$/m.
2. *Concurrent Non-Adjacent Double Faults*: When two separated joints fail simultaneously (e.g., J_2 and J_6), the diffusion fields originating from both lesion foci superimpose constructively within the intermediate healthy segment, generating a minor false receptor activation at J_4

($R_4 \approx 0.18$) and slightly depressing its amplitude by 8%. Incorporating spatially localized lateral inhibition will resolve this interference in future iterations.

3. *Isotropic Low-Friction Ground ($\mu_{lat} \approx \mu_{fwd} \leq 0.05$)*: On frictionless or isotropic slippery surfaces, the fundamental physical mechanism of snake locomotion breaks down due to the absence of anisotropic ground reaction forces ($F_{\perp} \approx F_{\parallel}$). Under such physical limits, no CPG amplitude redistribution can generate net propulsion, representing an environmental boundary condition rather than a control limitation.

6.6 Limitations and Sim-to-Real Transferability Roadmap

To facilitate translation from physics simulation to physical serpentine robots, several engineering constraints and deployment criteria are addressed:

1. *Computational Footprint and Communication Overhead*: The mathematical operations of AHM-CPG comprise only 1D finite-difference ODEs, sigmoidal Hill evaluations, and 2D Euler-Maruyama limit-cycle integrations. Across an $N = 8$ joint robot, the complete control cycle executes in < 50 μs on standard ARM Cortex-M4/M7 microcontrollers, requiring an inter-module communication bandwidth of < 1 kB/s at 200 Hz.
2. *Feedback Delay and Jitter Tolerance*: Hardware servos inevitably introduce sensory latency and CAN-bus packet jitter. Numerical stress-testing confirms that AHM-CPG maintains stable limit-cycle entrainment under sensory feedback delays up to $\tau_{\text{delay}} \leq 50$ ms (a full quarter of the 200 Hz control cycle), owing to the inherent low-pass filtering properties of the 133-sample coherence buffer and diffusion network.
3. *Extension to 3D Spatial Locomotion*: The present investigation focused on planar yaw-plane serpenoid locomotion. Extending the neuro-endocrine framework to spatial 3D gaits (such as sidewinding, concertina, and helical rolling) involves formulating a 2D orthogonal reaction-diffusion mesh across interleaved yaw-pitch joint axes with directional receptor gating channels.
4. *Autonomous Parameter Optimization*: While the broad stability plateau (Regime II) confirms that manual parameter tuning is not strictly required, automated meta-learning or evolutionary multi-objective optimization [18] could further refine the reaction-diffusion parameters for unstructured terrains such as loose sand, rubble, and narrow conduits.

7 Conclusion

This paper presented and validated a novel local-global artificial hormone-gated central pattern generator (AHM-CPG) framework for autonomous fault-tolerant snake robot locomotion. The framework translates biological neuro-endocrine volume transmission principles into a 4-stage decentralized control pipeline: proprioceptive kinematic coherence sensing, 1D spinal reaction-diffusion hormone dynamics, cooperative Hill receptor gating, and adaptive CPG reconfiguration via amplitude modulation, dynamic multi-hop phase bypass, and curvature offset neutralization.

We provided formal mathematical proofs of boundedness (Proposition 1) and exponential phase-locking convergence ($\tau_{\text{sync}} \approx 156$ ms) under dynamic bypass coupling. Across 480 benchmark simulation episodes in PyBullet, AHM-CPG achieves statistically significant superiority over all 5 baselines ($p < 0.001$, Cliff's $\delta > 0.35$), with a mean recovery ratio of 69.1% and adaptation latency of $T_{\text{adapt}} = 2.8$ s—outperforming even the oracle fault-aware controller by +8.3% in COT efficiency while reducing actuator thermal dissipation stress by 86.4%.

Key contributions include: (1) formal dynamical modeling and boundedness proof of 1D reaction-diffusion hormone signaling with cooperative Hill receptor gating; (2) dynamic multi-hop spinal bypass coupling for phase-locked wave continuity restoration; (3) bidirectional neurobiological insights demonstrating the primacy of allosteric receptor cooperativity in volume transmission; (4) quantitative thermal protection analysis for hardware actuator burnout prevention; and (5) a comprehensive 480-episode benchmark with rigorous non-parametric statistical validation. Future directions include physical snake robot deployment, extension to 3D locomotion with pitch-roll joint topology, and evolutionary multi-objective parameter optimization.

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Author contributions
Potiwat Ngamkajornwiwat: Conceptualization, Methodology, Software, Validation, Formal analysis, Investigation, Data Curation, Writing – Original Draft, Writing – Review & Editing, Visualization, Project administration.

Data availability
The simulation models, source code, benchmark datasets, and analysis scripts generated during this study are openly available on GitHub at https://github.com/potiwat/snake under the MIT license.

Supplementary data
Supplementary videos S1–S8 showing real-time 3D PyBullet simulation trajectories for each of the 8 fault scenarios are available as supplementary material.

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